



Testing ground: Sujeet Kalkal (right) during a bout at PWL 2026, which he called a valuable space for “knowledge exchange” between Indian and international wrestlers.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

nervous because it was happening after a long time. We didn’t have a lot of ideas about where we would stay or how we would train or compete,” says Sujeet Kalkal.

International wrestlers had their concerns, too.

“The time zone and food were going to be different. I’ve also never competed on a team with guys and girls. I’ve competed on a team, but that was usually all girls,” says Karla Godinez, 2022 World Championships bronze medallist for Canada.

Before she signed up for the player auction last December, Godinez says she spoke to wrestlers she knew who had taken part in previous editions of the league.

“(Olympic champions) Erica Wiebe (of Canada) and Helen Maroulis (of the USA) had competed in previous editions. When I spoke to them, they only had good things to say, and

that gave me confidence. The fact that the League was going to be held before the start of the international season also encouraged me. If it had been held in the middle of the year, for example, before the World Championships, I would not have taken part. I was also looking forward to experiencing a new culture and environment while also getting paid for it,” says Godinez, who wrestled for Delhi Dangal Warriors.

Most international wrestlers, though, were eager to sign up.

“A lot of guys from different countries wanted to get into this league. About 300 wrestlers tried to get into different clubs at the auction. Even now that I’ve come back to Ukraine, people ask me about the Indian League, how I travelled, how we fought, who we talked to. I got a lot of messages, both on Instagram and Facebook,” says Ukrainian heavyweight Oleksandr Khotsianivskyi, who wrestled for Tiigers of Mumbai Dangals.

Oleksandr, who had previously competed at the 2019 edition of the

League, as well as in other leagues such as the Bundesliga in Germany, says he had no reason to second-guess the decision.

“Compared to the last time I competed in India, there were a lot of changes. There was more of a show. The stadium in which the competition took place was big, the costumes were beautiful, and the organisation was better. Everything was at the highest level,” he says.

Oleksandr wasn’t the only one who appreciated the chance to compete in the League. Two-time Olympic medallist and Tokyo champion Yui Susaki, who was the highest-paid athlete at the auction, took the time to get a feel of the culture during her stay in India.

“I tried a lot of local food like butter chicken, and I also got the chance to see monuments like Humayun’s tomb,” Susaki told reporters.

The sightseeing was a bonus. The real point was the wrestling.

“The League is always a great experience for a professional athlete, because the strongest fighters from all over the world participate in the league. In any case, for a professional athlete, it is a confirmation of his level. It is good sparring and good competition. This year, the league was very strong,” says Oleksandr.

This was Susaki’s belief as well. The only time Susaki had ever been beaten in international competition was when she lost to India’s Vinesh Phogat at the Paris Olympics, and the Japanese wrestler said she came to India to suss out any future competition.

Although she only conceded points to one wrestler, Antim Panghal, Susaki had only good things to say about the opposition she saw in India.

“I heard that Indian wrestlers are very strong. That’s why I came to India. I think there are many young wrestlers who are good. They work very hard and have good mental strength,” Susaki told reporters during the League.

While Susaki had been looking forward to seeing the quality of